

Cases for Lab, weeks 1 - 2

Lying on one's resume

You've received a letter, asking for advice:

"I work at a small (fewer than 10 employees) firm as a mid-level associate. A few weeks ago, a close friend, Arielle — who doesn't work with me but lives in my city — showed me a photo of a woman while we were out to lunch and asked if she worked in my office. I said yes, it was our new (five months into the job) account coordinator, Megan. She said Megan is her cousin and that she had seen her post something on Facebook about where she worked and had connected the dots that it was my firm. She seemed surprised that Megan was working there, and she shared that Megan had only ever completed one semester of college and had been unemployed for seven years before getting this job. This surprised me, as I know that all positions at our firm require a college degree and cannot imagine we'd have hired someone with such a gap in employment.

Since it was bugging me, I went back and found the email HR sent out when Megan was hired. It included a little blurb about her and said she had earned her BA from a local university and had come to us with 10 years experience in the industry. I told this to Arielle, who said that that was the university Megan had dropped out of after one semester and reiterated that she had been entirely unemployed for the previous seven years. (Megan is only 32. She'd been married for most of that time and supported by her husband's income but began job searching after they divorced earlier this year.)

My question is, do I tell my bosses? Megan is fundamentally capable at her work and doesn't seem to be failing at anything. Most of her duties are clerical and client outreach, not things which are too difficult to pick up on the job. If she's not doing a bad job, is it worth bringing up to anyone that she does not have a degree or any of the experience preferred for the position she's in?"

What will you advise? Justify your answer.

Conflict of Interests

1. You are a sixth-year graduate student at a large university in the final months of your dissertation research on novel photonic materials. You are worried about your next appointment and have applied for several postdoctoral positions in this field plus a few tenure-track assistant professorships at universities where you would like to work. To your surprise and pleasure, you are invited for an interview for a tenure-track appointment at your undergraduate alma mater, a prestigious research institution in a city where you already have connections and would love to live. In the question-and-answer period following your seminar on your research, the department chair asks for detailed information about the novel material-preparation technique developed in your graduate research and used extensively in your experiments. Your group is working on a patent application and its members have agreed not to provide details until a paper currently being prepared is submitted for publication. Your thesis advisor will be giving the first major presentation on the technique at a major international conference in a couple months. You answer that you and your colleagues are in the process of writing it up for publication and a patent application, and you would be glad to send them an early preprint when it is available. The question-and-answer period continues and concludes uneventfully and pleasantly. After the seminar, in your private interview with the Chair, he pushes harder for this information, remarking that the Department seeks team players, willing to share information with department colleagues, and referring to your undergraduate roots and the need to prove you are one of them to be a viable candidate for the position.

What should you do?

{Questions • What are the interests of the various players? • Where are there conflicts of interest? • What are your options?}

2. A student finishes graduate studies working on a problem that has aspects that are directly patentable and solve a major problem in the disk drive industry. Her new job could be with Hitachi or Seagate, or some similar firm. She arrives at the new job and discovers that the work done as a student, which is in the patent process, will solve the problem at her new company. If she reveals what she knows to her new employer she will be an immediate hero but will compromise the patent process at her original institution. This step could have important financial implications for the original institution in the form of royalties.

What should she do?

3. In your spare time at work, you have developed a new spreadsheet program on the personal computer in your office. It is even more powerful, yet easier to use than anything on the market. You share your new program with a friend who encourages you to market it on your own because you could probably make an incredible profit in a very short time. This is a very attractive option, yet you developed it using company equipment and during time that you were at work.

What should you do? Why?